fewer [the responsible official] is berated. Three mouse holes are equal to one rat hole.'[66]

To facilitate this totalitarian system, the Qin attempted to create a militarised social order. Every male subject had to belong to a five-man unit. These units were aggregated into larger formations, from local hamlets (*li*), through cantons (*xiang*) and counties (*xian*), all the way to the large imperial commanderies (*jun*). People were forbidden to change their residence without permit, to the extent that guests could not even stay overnight at a friend's house without proper identification and authorisation.

Every Qin male subject was also given a rank, just as every soldier in an army has a rank. Obedience to the state resulted in promotion to higher ranks, which brought with it economic and legal privileges, while disobedience could result in demotion or punishment. People in each formation were supposed to supervise one another, and if any individual committed some misdeed, all could be punished for it. Anyone who failed to report a criminal – even their own relatives – would be killed. Those who reported crimes were rewarded with higher ranks and other perks.

It is highly questionable to what extent the regime managed to implement all these totalitarian measures. Bureaucrats writing documents in a government office often invent elaborate rules and regulations, which then turn out to be impractical. Did conscientious government officials really go around the entire Qin Empire counting rat holes in every granary? Were peasants in every remote mountain hamlet really organised into five-man squads? Probably not. Nevertheless, the Qin Empire outdid other ancient empires in its totalitarian ambitions.

The Qin regime even tried to control what its subjects were thinking and feeling. During the Warring States period Chinese thinkers were relatively free to develop myriad ideologies and philosophies, but the Qin adopted the doctrine of Legalism as the official state ideology. Legalism posited that humans were naturally greedy, cruel and egotistical. It emphasised the need for strict control, argued that punishments and rewards were the most effective means of control, and insisted that state power not be curtailed by any moral consideration. Might was right, and the good of the state was the supreme good.[67] The Qin proscribed other philosophies, such as Confucianism and Daoism, which believed humans were more altruistic and which emphasised the importance of virtue rather than violence.[68]